

Chemoradiation

Radiotherapy is sometimes given with chemotherapy. This is called chemoradiation. It is used as the main treatment for some types of cancer. It can also be used before or after surgery.

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What is chemoradiation?

Having chemotherapy at the same time as radiotherapy is called chemoradiation. It is sometimes called chemoradiotherapy.

[Chemotherapy](#) uses anti-cancer (cytotoxic) drugs to destroy cancer cells. [Radiotherapy](#) uses high-energy rays to destroy cancer cells.

The chemotherapy drugs can make cancer cells more sensitive to radiotherapy. Combining both treatments is often more effective than having either treatment on its own.

When is chemoradiation used?

This treatment is only helpful for certain types of cancer, so it is not suitable for everyone. Depending on the type of cancer, you may have chemoradiation:

- as your main treatment for cancer
- for cancers that cannot be removed with surgery
- before surgery, to help shrink the tumour. This is called neo-adjuvant treatment.
- after surgery, to reduce the risk of the cancer coming back. This is called adjuvant treatment.

We may have more about chemoradiation in our information about [different types of cancer](#).

Side effects of chemoradiation

We have more information about the [side effects of radiotherapy](#) and the [side effects of chemotherapy](#).

Giving chemotherapy and radiotherapy together can make the side effects of treatment worse. Your doctor or specialist nurse will give you more information about chemoradiation and the possible side effects.

Always tell your doctor, specialist nurse or radiographer about any side effects so they can help.

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 01 June 2022 | Next review: 01 June 2025

ⓘ This content is currently being reviewed. New information will be coming soon.

Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

How we can help

Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

[Get help](#)

